

USB 2.0 vs FireWire IEEE 1394: What's the Beef?		
	USB 2.0	FireWire IEEE 1394
Transfer Rate	480 MBps relates to a faster transfer rate	400 MBps (800 MBps is soon going to hit the market)
Availability	Next generation of motherboards will have this integrated	Very few motherboards have this port integrated. FireWire cards are relatively easy to find nowadays
Price	Relatively cheaper	Expensive
Compatibility with older protocols	Peripherals meant for USB 1.1 can still be run from this port	No compatibility issues
Who is backing which standard?	Intel's influence gives USB 2.0 a big advantage. With motherboards soon to have chipsets that directly support USB 2.0, it will be the best that could've happened to USB	Apple and the DV community. A huge number of DV camcorders and editors are already shipping with support for FireWire

Decision Maker				
	 Inexpensive data backup	 Speed demon	 Portability	
You need	Speed is not an issue; you are just looking for a cheap, reliable backup solution	Speed is everything, and you have no intention of spending more than 5-6 minutes to burn a CD	You regularly need to back up data from different PCs	
Look for	Any 16x drive	Preferably 20x or higher write speeds and a SCSI interface	A compact, external drive with a USB interface	
The models	LG GCE 8160B (16/10/40), Samsung SW-224 BRNS (24/10/40)	Yamaha CRW 3200E-VK (24/10/40), Plextor PX-W2410TA (24/10/40)	Impulse GCD 161040 (16/10/40), Yamaha CRW 2200IX-VK (20/10/40) FireWire	
Price range	Less than Rs 8,000	Rs 8,000 to 20,000	Rs 12,000 and above	

after time, impressing us with a consistently good performance—the Yamaha CRW 3200-VK. This writer wins the absolute performance crown hands down. It's built to last and built to perform. It also comes with a whopping 8 MB buffer that would ensure that you are not faced with a buffer underrun problem.

However, picking a winner for the Best Value Award was a tough one. The formidable Samsung SW-224 BRNS (24/10/40) bagged this award—owning a 24x CD-Writer for Rs 8,000 is an irresistible option. Sure you can buy cheaper CD-Writers rated at speeds lower than 24x but the absolute value that the Samsung drive offers coupled with sheer performance is unmatched.

At the same time, it would be unfair if we did not mention the Sony, Plextor and Asus drives. These were up there in every test, fighting it out neck and neck, claiming top spots on occasions.

As for the external writers, Yamaha CRW 2200IX-VK was unmatched in terms of pure performance and walked away with our Best Performance award. The Best Value award in this segment goes to the Acer CRW 4406EU for unflinching and reliable performance.

The Winners! Internal Writers

Yamaha CRW3200E-VK

Yamaha CRW3200E-VK is the fastest among the internal IDE drives. It burnt the assorted data in just 226 seconds (3 minutes 46 seconds) and took only 200 seconds (3 minutes 20 seconds) to write the 650 MB of music on a CD.



Yamaha's latest speed demon

It was also fast in rewriting the assorted data on the CD-RW at 10x, taking only 473 seconds (7 minutes 53 seconds), which is again very low time. The drive had a massive 8 MB buffer which is one of the highest capacity buffers in a CD-Writer.

The drive had good build quality and came bundled with Nero v5.5, InCD Nero Toolkit and Nero Mix. In addition, the pack included Yamaha's 650 MB blank CD-R and 750 MB CD-RW media, as well as IDE and audio cables. However, the writer is available for Rs 15,000, which makes it one of the most expensive internal drives.

SPECIFICATIONS
24/10/40x speed, 8 MB buffer, EIDE/ATAPI interface

Samsung SW-224BRNS (24/10/40)

The SW-224 24x writer is one of the fastest writers as far as writing assorted data on a CD-RW goes—it took 476 seconds (less than 8 minutes) to burn 650 MB of data at 10x speed. To write data in the RAW mode, it took a mere 235 seconds, which again is one of the lowest time taken for this test.

The build quality is average but the front panel has a distinctive look, with the tray's corners



Fast and doesn't burn a hole in your pocket

rounded off and an illuminated eject button. This Samsung drive incorporates Burn Proof technology but its 2 MB buffer is a bit less. The writer came bundled with a manual, IDE/audio cable, multi-speed CD-R and 10x CD-RW blank media. The burning software included with the writer was Nero v5.5, which is the latest offering from AHEAD software. At Rs 8,000, it is ideal for both home and office users, who burn CDs on a daily basis and for whom time is a critical factor.

SPECIFICATIONS
24/10/40x speed, 2 MB buffer, tray interface, SPDIF out